



In safe hands: Alcaraz's coach, Juan Carlos Ferrero, played a strong hand in the former's resurgence on court.

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deceptive forehand drop shot winner. 6-3 for Alcaraz.

Sinner had lost the momentum but not his fighting spirit. The critical point in the deciding set came at 1-all with Sinner serving to escape his second break point. Like a high-speed video game, it ended in a spectacular second. Alcaraz sprinted for a net cord as if his life depended on reaching it. He scraped it up only to set up Sinner, who drilled a forehand crosscourt passing shot. Alcaraz dove for it, and seemingly put the ball away with a volley.

But just as desperately, Sinner dove for it and somehow reflexed a low backhand over the net. Alcaraz recovered in time to deliver a backhand volley winner. Athleticism trumped determination.

Sinner landed on his left wrist. He didn't call for the trainer. How much

it affected his play, we may never know. Like a true competitor, he soldiered on and didn't make excuses.

But Alcaraz raced to a 5-1 lead. Before Sinner served the next game, Cahill yelled, "Try something different this game. You never know what can happen. Be unpredictable, mate!"

It was too late, though. The irresistible force called Alcaraz prevailed 1-6, 6-3, 6-2. He then went on to defend his Indian Wells title in the final, snapping the longest title drought of his young, but brilliant, career.

"This [match against Sinner] was one of the most intelligent performances we've seen — tactically astute," said Jason Goodall, a *Tennis Channel* analyst, while Juan Carlos Ferrero pointed to his head.

Both a slump and a streak were broken, and both stars benefited from yet another thrilling encounter.

"It's difficult to put it into words, because I had really difficult

months," Alcaraz said afterward. "Let's say the last two months it was difficult for me to find myself. I didn't enjoy stepping on the court. I wasn't myself on the court the last two months, three months, so it was difficult for me. It doesn't matter what problems you have. If you believe in yourself, you have a really good team around you, you work hard, everything can turn around. I think that's the biggest lesson that I take from this tournament."

Sinner will go back to the drawing board with coach Cahill and undoubtedly make some tactical changes. "You are always impressed when you play against him," a gracious Sinner said. "He's moving really, really fast, as we know. Especially on this court, where the ball bounces really high, it's not easy to play against him because he can play with a lot of spin. But what I have missed today [is] that I was too predictable at some points. I was doing the same things over and over again, which in my mind let me